Long sentences: participle phrases and relative clauses

Understand it

Participle phrases shorten relative clauses. -ing means the noun does the action (people living here = people who live here); -ed means the action is done to the noun (houses built in 1900 = houses that were built in 1900).

Passage 3 is full of these structures. Practise expanding them back into full clauses.

The rules

- Participle phrases shorten a clause: Students studying abroad = students who are studying abroad. The bridge built in 1890 = which was built.
- -ing = active meaning; -ed = passive meaning. The results shown in the table = which are shown.
- Relative clauses and participle phrases both add information to a noun: find the noun and then the phrase.
- Several ideas in one sentence: cut at the commas and find each small idea.

All the words and forms you need

Active (-ing)	people working at home · students taking the test · animals living in caves
Passive (-ed / 3rd form)	data collected in 2020 · goods made in China · the method described above
At the start of a sentence	Having finished the test, … · Built in 1900, the bridge … · Faced with the problem, …
Relative clauses to reduce	who / which + is / are + -ing → -ing · who / which + was / were + -ed → -ed

Where you use it

Reading: Matching headings and summaries often need you to understand a long academic sentence.

Listening: Lectures contain long spoken sentences: listen to the first and last words.

Writing: Use one participle phrase per paragraph to add variety.

Speaking: Keep sentences shorter than in writing.

More examples

- Students taking the test must arrive early.
- The figures shown in the table are from 2019.
- Built in 1889, the tower was once the tallest in the world.
- Having finished the experiment, the team wrote a report.
- Many birds migrating south stop here.

- Goods produced locally are cheaper to transport.

Common mistakes

Wrong	Right
✗ Students who studying abroad ...	✓ Students studying abroad ... / who study abroad
✗ The data collecting last year.	✓ The data collected last year.
✗ The woman wearing in red.	✓ The woman wearing red.

Speaking practice: answer using this grammar

1. Describe a photo of people doing different things (people sitting, people walking ...).
2. Describe a building built a long time ago in your town.
3. What do you do having finished your homework?

Writing practice

Reduce: The people who live in the north speak a dialect. / The report, which was published in May, was criticized.

Practice

1. Shorten: The students who are waiting outside are late.

2. Shorten: The book that was written in 1990 is famous.

3. Expand: Children raised in cities ...

4. Find the noun: The data collected last year shows ...

5. Correct: The man standing the door is my uncle.

6. Shorten: The report, which was published in May, ...

Answers

1. The students waiting outside are late.
2. The book written in 1990 is famous.
3. Children who are raised in cities ...
4. data
5. The man standing at the door is my uncle.
6. The report, published in May, ...